

A place for things on their way somewhere else

Milestone 1: the problem space restated, and the opportunities the neighbours overlook. A menu-bar staging area where everything is comfortable being temporary.

working title: Airlock · full spec on branch [docs/specs/macOS-companion](#)

Drop or paste something on its way somewhere else



postgres://ops:.....@db-3.internal:5432/prod

47 chars · pasted 14:02

8h

[↗ link](#)



Screenshot — error dialog, build 4471

image · 212 KB · dropped 09:47

3h

[↗ link](#)

A SleeperCell. The ring drains in real time; click the 8h label to cycle the TTL ladder. The [↗ link](#) is the only path off this machine.

The busiest, least-designed surface on the desktop

The clipboard is the highest-traffic data conduit on any computer, and it has barely been designed at all: one anonymous slot, no history, no expiry, no notion of sensitivity. Every

password, 2FA code, API token, screenshot, and half-written paragraph passes through it.

Because the clipboard is inadequate, people improvise **staging areas** — places for content that is *between* an origin and a destination. And the improvised options are all wrong in the same direction: **they retain**. Clipboard managers record everything, indefinitely. Notes apps fossilize secrets in “Untitled 47”, synced to a cloud account. A Slack message to yourself persists on someone else’s servers. The desktop piles up, gets backed up, gets screen-shared.

The problem is not storage — storage is oversolved. The problem is **staging**: a place designed for content whose defining property is that it is in transition, and should stop existing when the transition ends.

The cache analogy, taken seriously

The framing is “an L1/L2 cache for the clipboard”, and the analogy holds under weight — it is the spec in miniature:

small	A working set, not an archive. A dozen cells, never a thousand rows of history. Smallness keeps the whole state legible at a glance.
close	One keystroke or glance away, docked at the screen edge — in peripheral vision, adjacent to the work, never in front of it.
evicts by policy	Nobody cleans up a CPU cache. Every cell has a TTL from arrival; expiry is the default lifecycle. <i>Keeping</i> something is what requires intent.
never authoritative	A cache never owns the data; the source of truth is elsewhere. Losing a cell is a minor re-fetch, never a catastrophe — which is what lets the app skip sync, backup, and anxiety entirely.

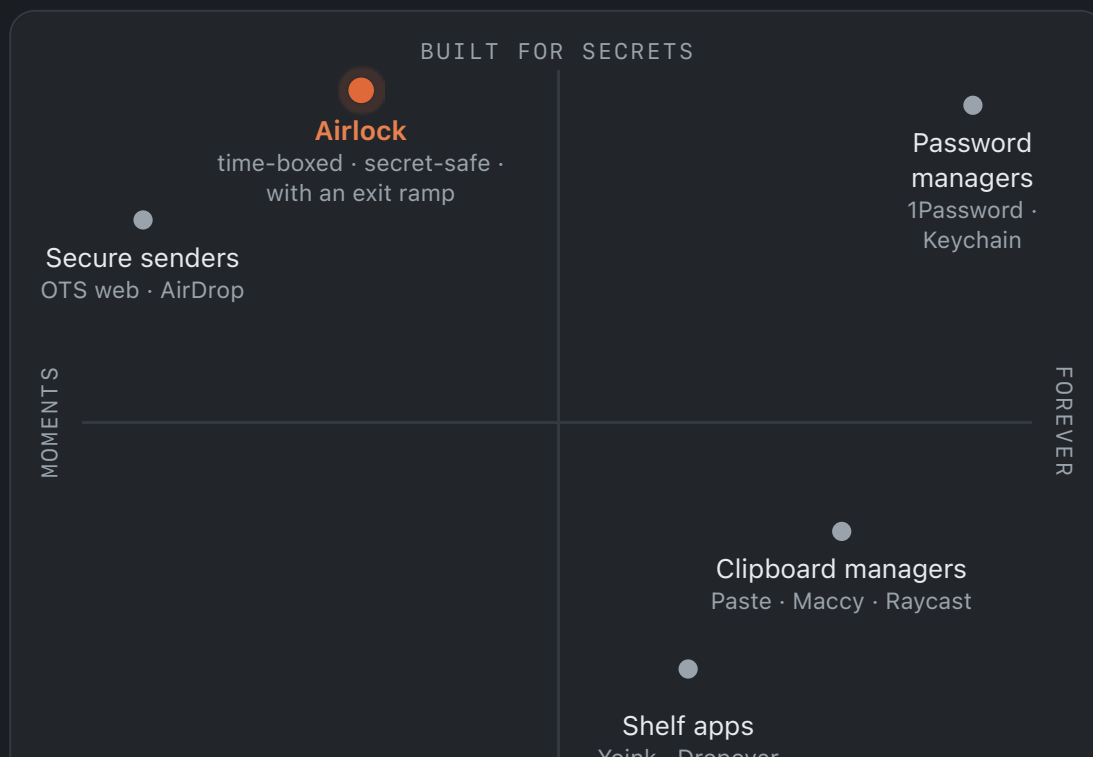
one access pattern Caches win by refusing generality. This one is optimized for put → brief hold → copy out → forget, and declines every workload outside it.

write-back The one deliberate extension: a cell can be written back to a slower, more durable tier — promotion to a Onetime Secret link, for content that must reach another person. Same philosophy, one tier further out.

Every neighbouring product treats retention as the value and expiry as a setting. This product inverts that: **the guarantee of disappearance is the value**. That inversion is what makes it trustworthy for sensitive content — the convenient thing and the hygienic thing become the same thing. And it removes the accumulation tax: an empty panel is the system working, not the product failing at engagement.

The open position

Four families of apps border this space. None occupies it.



Short-lived + secret-safe has no incumbent. Senders have no staging; stagers have no sending.

The incumbents can't easily follow. Clipboard managers cannot abandon automatic capture and history — it *is* their product. Shelf apps without a security posture would have a decaying shelf, not a staging area. Password managers adding a "temporary" tier would undermine their archive-of-record promise. And the quadrant resists monetization (nothing accrues, no lock-in) — survivable precisely because this is an open-source companion whose job is to make Onetime Secret more present, not to be a business by itself.

What the neighbours overlook

OPPORTUNITY

WHY IT'S OURS TO TAKE

Time as the interface

Everywhere else expiry is buried metadata. Here, time-remaining is each cell's most prominent attribute — a glance answers the only question a staging area gets asked: what's in flight, and how long does it have?

TTL as direct manipulation

Click the label to cycle 1h → 3h → 8h → 24h → 3d → 7d, resetting the clock. One affordance replaces a preferences pane and a date picker. There is no "forever" on the wheel — deliberately.

Deliberate placement as the privacy model

Nothing is captured automatically; everything present was placed by intent. This single decision deletes the "my clipboard manager recorded my password" problem class and keeps the panel 100% signal.

The promotion gradient

Local cell → one-time link is the same idea — ephemeral, view-limited — extended from one

machine to two parties. One click, remaining TTL seeds the secret's TTL, and the local copy offers to burn.

Auditable ephemerality

Open source, memory-only by default, no telemetry, no account in the core loop. "It forgets" is a checkable claim, not a slogan — a posture closed-source incumbents can't match cheaply.

Frugality as a felt difference

Rust-native: near-zero idle CPU (expiry scheduled, never polled), tens of MB resident, single-digit MB download, zero connections at rest — against a field of 300 MB Electron residents.

The macOS security surface, actually used

Outbound copies marked `ConcealedType` so clipboard managers ignore them; panel excluded from screen capture; clear-after-copy; zeroized, non-swappable buffers.

Accessibility in a category that ignores it

Menu-bar utilities are keyboard-hostile and screen-reader opaque as a class. Every operation keyboard-complete; TTL exposed as an adjustable VoiceOver value; urgency never colour-only.

Six principles

Each earns its place by settling real design arguments. When two conflict, the earlier one wins.

1 • Comfortable being temporary

Expiry is the promise, not a limitation to soften. Never apologize for deleting; no safety net that quietly becomes an archive.

Settles: no expiry notifications, no "recently expired" bin, no trash can.

2 · Present, not centre stage

The app is furniture — peripheral vision, never stealing focus, at its best when forgotten between uses. Attention consumed per transfer is the metric, minimized.

Settles: no badge counts, no drop-success notifications, no dock icon, focus stays with the user's work.

3 · Content plays second fiddle

Cells are handles for content in motion, not a display of it: a trimmed line or thumbnail, a kind glyph, a size. Recognition, not consumption.

Settles: no markdown rendering, no in-place editing, no content-on-hover (a shoulder-surfing surface).

4 · Frugal

In resources (native code, memory-only, no polling), in attention (see 2), and in scope — features adding retention, organization, or engagement are declined by default.

Settles: no Electron, no resident update daemon, no telemetry, no iCloud sync.

5 · Trust through legibility

Always answerable at a glance: what does it hold, when does each item die, does anything leave this machine (only on explicit promotion). No hidden state, and every claim auditable in the open source.

Settles: never auto-capture the clipboard, no local history of promoted secrets, no phoning home.

6 · Escalate deliberately

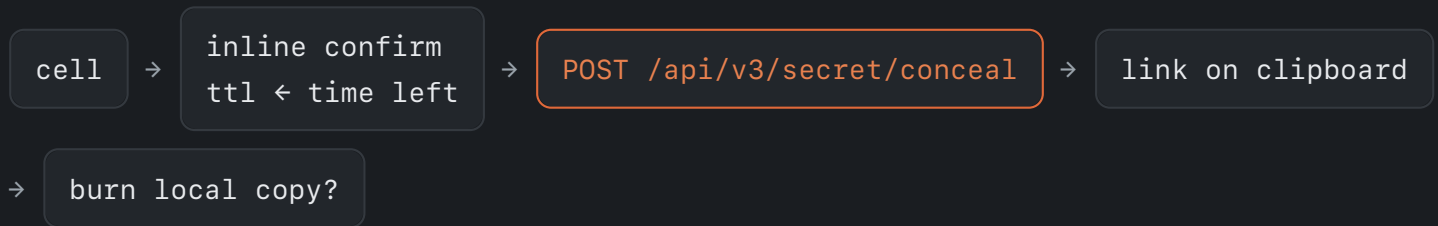
Local first; remote by explicit choice. Promotion is the only network operation, unmistakably an action, never a side effect.

Settles: no auto-created links, no preemptive uploads, no account required at install.

The secondary interaction: promotion

One click from “held here” to “en route, one-time, encrypted” — with the content never

passing through a browser tab or sitting exposed in the single-slot clipboard along the way:



Authentication starts with HTTP Basic — organization extid plus an API key pair, held in the Keychain — and migrates to PASETO bearer tokens when v3 auth ships; the client crate isolates auth as a swappable strategy. Where a server enables guest routes, promotion works with zero configuration. Deliberately absent from v1: receipt browsing, remote burn beyond the live cell, secret generation. A staging area with an exit ramp, not an API console.

The spec, in full

Seven documents on the branch, written so milestone 2 has something concrete to disagree with:

README.md	Index, summary, naming note
01-problem-space.md	Restatement, cache analogy, moments, anti-goals — core deliverable
02-overlooked-opportunities.md	Landscape, the empty quadrant, why incumbents won't follow — core deliverable
03-design-principles.md	Six principles and the arguments they settle
04-interaction-model.md	SleeperCell anatomy, TTL ladder, panel behaviour, keyboard map — draft

05-technical-direction.md

Rust shell survey (Tauri 2 vs Swift-shell vs gpui...), security posture, a11y, frugality budget — draft

06-open-questions.md

Sixteen unresolved questions with current leanings

Set in the platform's own voice — New York, SF Pro, and SF Mono via system stacks — because the subject is a native macOS citizen. The ember accent is Onetime Secret's own #d45a2a. The demo ring drains on a 90-second loop (paused under reduced motion); a real cell drains over hours.